

Unit Y318: Russia and its Rulers 1855–1964

This theme focuses on the nature of Russian government and its impact on the Russian people and society. Learners should understand the similarities and differences between the autocratic rule of the tsars to 1917 and the subsequent Communist dictatorship. The strands identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme.

Thematic Study: Russia and its Rulers 1855–1964	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The nature of government	Autocracy, dictatorship and totalitarianism, developments in central administration; methods of repression and enforcement; the extent and impact of reform; the nature, extent and effectiveness of opposition both before and after 1917, changes in local government; attitude of the Tsars, Provisional Government and Communists to political change; the extent of political change.
The impact of dictatorial regimes on the economy and society of the Russian Empire and the USSR	Changes to living and working conditions of urban and rural people including the impact on the peasants of Emancipation, Land Banks, famines, NEP, collectivisation and the Virgin Land scheme, the impact of industrial growth under the Tsars, War communism, NEP and the Five Year Plans on industrial workers; limitations on personal, political and religious freedom; reasons for and extent of economic and social changes.
Impact of war and revolution on the development of the Russian Empire and the USSR	The effects of the following wars on government, society, nationalities and the economy: the Crimean War, the Japanese War, 1905 Revolution, 1917 Revolutions, First World War, Second World War, the Cold War.
Russia: Empire, nationalities and satellite states	The Polish Revolt 1863; expansion in Asia; Russification; Finland; the Baltic provinces; impact of the First World War and the Treaty of Brest Litovsk; Russo-Polish War; Communist advance into Eastern and Central Europe after the Second World War.

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Depth Studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Alexander II's domestic reforms	The effects of the Crimean War; the aims of Alexander II's domestic policies; the nature of his government; changes in central administration; the extent and impact of domestic reform; the extent and effectiveness of opposition; changes in urban and rural living and working conditions; limitations on personal, political and religious freedom; extent of economic and social change.
The Provisional Government	Main domestic policies of the Provisional Government; the nature of the government; methods of repression and enforcement; the extent and impact of reform; the extent and effectiveness of opposition; changes in urban and rural living and working conditions, limitations on personal, political and religious freedom; extent of economic and social changes; the impact of the continuing war; reasons for the overthrow of the Provisional Government.
Khrushchev in power 1956–1964	The aims of Khrushchev; the nature of his government; opposition, methods and enforcement of repression in Russia and its satellites; the extent and impact of reform; changes in urban and rural living and working conditions; limitations on personal, political and religious freedom; extent of economic and social changes including economic planning and the Virgin Lands Scheme; the impact of the Cold War; Khrushchev's fall.